a higher level.' The kind of values Ulbricht instilled on his protégé is entirely clear. He took lessons in learning intrigue, manipulation, patience and the deployment of innuendo and half-truths – tools essential for survival in the corridors of communist power.

With his position in the Politburo confirmed, Honecker tore off around the GDR giving rousing speeches on his usual themes about subversion, greater military strength, and launching an ideological counter-offensive against fascism and capitalism. He mixed with the rank and file, was articulate and knowledgeable, and engaged in small talk rather than shop.

Meanwhile, in the wider world, the unintended consequences of Khrushchev's speech and subsequent thaw had led to substantial disenchantment towards the Soviet Union in Poland; while in November 1956, the first flames of revolution in Central Europe saw a violent uprising of workers and students in Hungary, which brought the government such distress that only the intervention of the Soviet army could stabilise the situation. Aided by Moscow, Honecker used the Hungarian 'counter-revolution' as an excuse to further tighten security. 'He was aware that the working class would never forgive the SED and the GDR government if they had neglected to strengthen the armed forces in this situation … he devoted himself to this task with great energy,' a state-penned biography published in 1977 asserted.2 Through his own dedication, the hagiography added, Honecker 'did much to strengthen the cause of socialism and to raise the overall level of political and ideological work in the army'.

Around this time, the entire SED apparatus – including Honecker – moved to a new Central Committee building on Werderscher Markt in the former Reichsbank, for which Adolf Hitler had laid the foundation stone in 1934. From then on, this concrete behemoth became the supreme centre of power in the German Democratic Republic. Honecker held court in chambers on the third floor from where he kicked-off a frenzied pursuit of critical intellectuals, who, encouraged by Khrushchev's reforms, demanded liberalisation of society, or a so-called 'third way', and 'human socialism'. Dissenting voices were loudest at the University of Berlin, where the resignation of Stalinists was openly demanded. Having helped to purge resentment in the capital, Honecker spread his tentacles far and wide and